

DECISION READINESS NOTE (DRN-004)

TITLE: NOISE AS DECISION-SIGNAL INTERFERENCE IN OPERATIONAL ENVIRONMENTS

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Status: Anonymized | Observational | Non-enforcement

Evidence Basis: Lived Operational Exposure and Ongoing Observation

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1. Context

Domain: Operational / Industrial environments

Decision Surface: Detection, interpretation, and response to signals (auditory or radio) under high interference conditions.

2. Observed Structural Pattern

- Operational environments generate sustained ambient noise (machinery, wind, processing) that degrades auditory perception.
- Critical alerts and coordination commands compete with this environmental "noise floor."
- Radio communication clarity varies across locations and operational conditions.
- Decision-making proceeds using standard communication protocols, even when signal fidelity is compromised.

3. Decision Reframe

The operative decision is not whether noise exists. The real decision is:

Does the communication protocol shift to a higher standard of verification when environmental noise degrades the signal?

4. Decision Failure Mode

Failure Type: Assumption of Standard Transmission

The system relies on "Broadcast" methods (yelling, general radio calls) rather than "Handshake" methods (eye contact, repeat-backs).

It assumes the signal *sent* is identical to the signal *received*, ignoring the degradation caused by the environment.

5. Accountability Consequence

- Individuals are held accountable for not acting on signals they may never have effectively received.
- Transmission failures are classified as individual inattention rather than environmental interference.
- Incidents are attributed to "failure to follow instructions" rather than "failure to verify receipt."

6. Decision Readiness Assessment

The system manages hazards (PPE for ears) but does not reliably manage:

- signal-to-noise ratios at critical decision points
- mandatory redundancy (hand signals + radio)
- positive verification loops (sender ensures receiver understood)

7. Minimal Diagnostic Question

When a signal-dependent error occurs, can the system demonstrate that the protocol required positive verification of receipt (e.g., a read-back or physical acknowledgment) before the action proceeded?

If not, the system is not decision-ready.

End of DRN-004